HOOK

More code. Same number of shipped features.

That's the uncomfortable pattern showing up in team after team.

- Coding agents are fast at producing lines of code
- Shipped, working software isn't moving at the same rate
- The gap is forcing a hard question about where time actually goes

WHY IT'S BLOWING UP

Because it breaks the core assumption about AI coding

The assumption was: faster typing equals faster delivery.

- A widely discussed study found volume up, output flat
- It's hitting HN front page with fast-rising engagement
- Teams are recognizing the pattern in their own workflows

THE MECHANISM

Typing was never the real bottleneck

Writing code was always the fast part of software delivery.

- Design decisions take time, not keystrokes
- Review, testing, and integration were always the slow steps
- Agents sped up the one step that wasn't the constraint

WHAT ACTUALLY SLOWS TEAMS DOWN

The real bottlenecks haven't changed

These are the same constraints teams had before AI agents.

- Unclear requirements and shifting scope
- Code review capacity and reviewer attention
- Testing, QA, and integration with existing systems
- Deployment, rollback plans, and production monitoring

WHAT THIS LOOKS LIKE IN PRACTICE

More PRs. Same release cadence.

Volume increases upstream, while delivery stays capped downstream.

- Agents generate pull requests faster than humans can review
- Reviewers become the new constraint, not the writing
- Backlogs of unreviewed or unintegrated code start piling up

THE LESSON

Speeding up one step doesn't speed up the system

A system moves at the pace of its slowest constraint.

- Optimizing code generation without fixing review is wasted gain
- Agentic coding helps most when paired with review automation
- Output volume is a vanity metric; shipped software is the real one

PRACTICAL TAKEAWAY

Before adopting agents, map your actual bottleneck

Ask where work really gets stuck before adding more code volume.

- Track time from PR open to merge, not just code written
- Identify whether review, testing, or deploy is the real constraint
- Invest agent capability where the constraint actually sits

CTA

Where does your delivery pipeline actually slow down?

Not where it feels slow. Where the data says it's slow.

- I build workflow and automation systems around real constraints
- Happy to compare notes on where coding agents fit in your pipeline

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